

Unresolved Business

Saelunere, Episode Two

Parvo, in the year 756

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The first day of winter, and the city went to work.

Nothing waited for anybody. The stalls came down off Oblong Square overnight and the boards were swept before it was properly light. The stage was taken apart and carried away in pieces on a cart. The season turned over from Terr to Tide between one sleep and the next, and by the middle of the morning there was nothing on those cobbles to say that anything had happened on them at all. Every person who had stood in that square and watched a man die was expected at his post at the usual hour, and as far as the city was concerned that was the end of it.

So the five of them went: Felix to the spire, Lark to the depot, Billiam to the scrapyard, Calder to the College, and Aeska down the stairs of a tavern he had not meant to be sleeping above. None of them knew what any of the others were doing.

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Lark did not go to bed at all.

She went to the bathhouse first, which was near where she slept and where they knew her well enough not to ask, and she stayed in it a long time, working another man's blood out from under her nails and off her forearms and out of the weave of the scarf. The scarf kept it. She wrung it out twice and the water came up pink both times, and in the end she folded it wet and took it with her. The wraps on her arms she unwound and did not put back on. Afterwards she walked home through streets that were being swept and lay down on her bunk in the dark, with the other couriers breathing around her. Every time she shut her eyes she was looking at Theo again, at the moment his chest opened and the sentence stopped. She came up out of it each time in a cold sweat with her heart going. That went on until the window went grey and there was no more point in it.

The Aelsdae run had to go out, so she took it: the same packages she takes every Aelsdae, one side of the city to the other, along a route she could have walked asleep and very nearly did.

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Felix went in because staying away would have been noticed.

He took the elevator he always took, up to the floor in the middle of the spire where his own small office sat beside Theo's, and when the doors opened he stepped out into a corridor full of people who did not work there. A dozen of them, guild uniforms he could not place, clerks with satchels under their arms and two or three guardsmen standing along the wall with the particular stillness of men who have been brought along in case. In the middle of it was Chief Secretary Spurnhold, who ran the secretarial staff and had never in Felix's experience raised her voice, holding the whole crowd off a locked door with nothing but procedure.

"Please. Please, there's no need for any of this. I've locked his office and we will be going through the correct procedures for someone who has unfortunately passed away." Then she saw him over their heads, and something in her face let go. "Oh, look, it's Felix now. His secretary. You can deal with him directly. I'll be in my office."

And she went off through them, and a dozen faces came round to him instead.

"We've just got orders to look through the deceased's belongings," one of them said, "to ensure that there are no guild secrets or anything that might fall into the wrong hands following his change of position. Obviously somebody will need to

be promoted, and we just want to be certain there is nothing in there that could fall outside the correct seniority within the guild. I'm sure you understand."

Felix said that he understood, and asked whether he was expected to go through all of it himself.

"Well, if you want to assist us with the search, that would be actually excellent." The man glanced at the door. "Your chief secretary locked the office. Have you got a key?"

He had a key, and he could have said that he did not. He stood there with his hand in his pocket and the dozen of them waiting, and then he took it out and unlocked Theo's office and stood back and let them past him into it.

What followed was the strangest morning of his working life. He knew that room the way you know a room you have filed things in every day for a year, and he used it. He stayed at their shoulders the whole time, reaching things down before they were asked for, opening drawers for them, so enormously helpful that not one of them ever had to look for anything on his own. Which meant that not one of them ever opened anything Felix had not watched him open. It is very hard to search a room properly with a man in it who is better at finding things than you are.

He came out of it sure of two things. The first was that they were doing exactly what they had said they were doing. There was no second search running quietly inside the first one. They went through the maintenance files and the correspondence and the quarterly reports, found the ordinary paperwork of a man who had supervised essence transfer for a living, and were plainly bored by all of it. The second was that there was nothing in that office. Nothing hidden, nothing awkward, nothing kept back, not so much as a letter that had no business being there. Which told Felix something about Theo he had never consciously worked out before: whatever else the man had been doing with his evenings, he had not trusted one page of it to this building.

They filed out after a couple of hours and left the room turned over behind them, and Spurnhold came back in and stood looking at the mess rather than at him.

"Now, Felix, this is an odd situation. Your current role, I don't believe you've been with us long enough to immediately move into Theo's position. Although you currently know the most about his work. So we would ask that you sit in as interim Chief of Essence Transfer. Just for a couple of weeks, until things are sorted. Would you be alright with that?"

He said that he would.

"Perfect. Perfect." She was halfway out of the room before she stopped and came back a step. "I must say. I am very troubled to hear that you were present

last night. It must be very hard for you.”

“Yes. Yes, indeed. I’m sorry. It was so close to me when it happened.”

“That’s horrible. Horrible to hear. Theo was a great employee here.” A beat, and then more kindly: “If you need to take an hour or two off, you’re more than welcome. Take a long lunch.”

He did not take a long lunch. He spent the afternoon at Theo’s desk with Theo’s reports in front of him and the drawers still hanging open where the clerks had left them, and discovered something he could have predicted and had never once bothered to, which was that he understood the filing completely and the work not at all. He knew which report went where and what the deadlines were and whose signature belonged at the bottom of which page, and he could not have told anybody what a single line of any of it meant. It was like being handed a shipwright’s yard because you were good at the paperwork, and asked to build the boat.

He worked out the day, and went home, and paid his costs, and slept.

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Aeska woke in a room above the Plumb and Bob, which was not where he had expected to be sleeping when the week began, and came down to find Harl already setting up with the shutters still half closed.

“Morning, Harl. Wild night, huh?”

“You can be sure about that.” Harl did not stop what he was doing. “Not seen that much excitement in a while. Theo though. God.” He straightened up with a crate against his hip. “I mean, I didn’t want to come out and get involved or anything, right? But he was dead, right?”

“From what I can gather, and from what we saw. He’s no longer for this world.”

“Right. Right.”

Aeska let a moment go by. Then he asked whether Harl had happened to hear anything, because to him this was looking like more than an assassination, and Harl put down the crate and thought about it properly.

“Nah. I mean, Theo’s been coming here every week, right. Holding some talks and things back there, in the back room. Comes every Ersdae and has a talk or something.” He wiped along the bar without looking at what he was wiping. “I don’t pay attention, honestly. People pay me to keep my head down. They use the back room for whatever they want and I don’t ask any questions, so I’ve got no idea what he was talking about in there. I heard a few people come and go, that’s

all. That Lark girl was around here last night as well, and she's a regular at these meetings, so she'd probably tell you more than I can. But that's really the only thing I know about Theo. He comes in, does his thing, friendly with everyone. I ain't heard a bad word said about him."

Aeska asked whether any of the people he met with stood out. A mixed bag, Harl said: Core and Stacks people mostly, none of the fancy noble lot, a few who wander in off the street and see something interesting and stay to listen, and then a handful of regulars whose faces he knew and whose names he did not. He could point them out in a crowd. That was as far as it went.

Then Aeska asked for the thing he had come downstairs for. He said that he was going to get to the bottom of this. He said he would be grateful for whatever help Harl could give him, and that Harl knew what his relationship with Theo had been, and knew as well as anyone why this needed to stay quiet. And then he asked whether Harl might keep his doors open to him, including, he said, the doors that are not generally used by the customers.

Harl weighed him up for a while, and then reached under the bar and came up with a small iron key.

"Alright. This is for the back door. Can't give you the front, I've only got the one. But you can come and go as you please out the back." He kept his thumb on it after Aeska had hold of the other end. "Just don't drag any shit in here that might incriminate me, alright? I don't want to get involved with the guilds any more than I have to. I've had enough of that in my life. So look. You can use the place. But try and keep me out of it."

"I appreciate it. And we share the same interest there. Guild-wise, I would rather not be involved with them either."

"Big fancy noble, are you." Harl's face did something complicated. "That was interesting to hear last night. That explains a lot, that does." He put both hands flat on the bar. "But look, I ain't about to get in the way of no fancy nobles like yourself, my lord. You can come and go as you please and I won't say a word about it."

"Let's just say that is one of the bigger parts I would like to keep quiet, if possible."

"Understood."

Aeska put the key in an inside pocket, finished his tea standing up, and went out the back way to use it on somebody else's door.

Theo's house stands high up in the Stacks, and getting to it is a business of ladders and ramps and ducking under other people's washing, and Aeska did not go straight to the door when he got there. He walked the length of the street first. There were people about, because it was the middle of the morning and

this is the Stacks and it is never otherwise, but none of them were watching the house and none of them were pretending not to. He had been here two years ago and nothing about it had changed: small, smart, well kept, the paint better than anything on either side of it, and every window dark.

He waited for a lull, and tried the door, and found it locked. He had no picks with him, so he worked the blade of his dagger into the gap between door and frame and leaned his weight onto it until the lock came apart with a crunch that carried further up the street than he would have liked.

Inside had already been done.

Everything out and everything over, drawers on the floor and shelves cleared onto the floor under them: the work of several people in a hurry who had not expected the owner home. He got the broken door shut behind him as well as it would shut, and stood in the dark of the front room and let his eyes come round to it.

He had known Theo at the guild two years ago, well enough to know that the man kept nothing important in an office. Whatever there was would be in this room. So he went through it slowly, on his knees, righting drawers and turning over what had come out of them.

He did not find any papers. What he found instead was where the papers had been: a drawer with a clean gap in the middle of a packed run, a shelf with nothing across two feet of it and dust at both ends of the nothing. Things had been lifted out of this house. They had not simply never been in it.

Somebody had come here on the night Theo died, and taken what Theo had, and left the rest on the floor.

He let himself out and went away up the street, and as far as he could tell nobody saw him arrive and nobody saw him leave.

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Billiam's parents had both gone by the time he woke, which was normal, so he ate on his own, and then he went down the ladders and across the edge of the Core to the scrapyard, the same walk he makes nine days in ten.

Claringbone's yard takes essence machinery apart for whatever can be got off it and sold on. A couple of the other lads were already at it when he came through the gate. He went to find Shrapnel first, the way he does at the start of every shift. Shrapnel runs that yard from behind a desk and has run it a long time, and he has the look of a man who once did something considerably harder than this.

“Oh. Billy.”

“Hi, Shrapnel. Good morning.”

“You look rough.”

“Didn’t you hear? That business at Oblong Square.”

“Sure, I heard about it. What’s it got to do with you?”

“Well. Theodore Blackwood was killed, right.” He had not planned any of this and it came out in the wrong order. “He was a friend of my father. But more importantly, I was there when it happened. It was kind of a crazy night. And that’s, that’s also what I wanted to talk to you about a bit. With a few others, we tried to help Theodore, but it was already too late. And then some of the guys from the Guild of Engineers came by and they took his body, and they just kind of - ” He stopped, and started again somewhere else. “It seems like they were trying to cover it up. Even though it was such a public murder.”

Shrapnel let that sit for a while before he answered.

“Well, look. You’re young, right. The guild’s messing around with everyone’s business, that’s nothing new in this city, I’ll tell you.” He put down what he was holding. “But that Theo was a guild man himself, weren’t he. Guild of Engineers, I think, if I know who you’re talking about.”

“Yeah. Actually, he was the one who helped me get this job.”

“Oh, right. Friend of a friend. Sure, sure.” He turned a hand over. “Well then. It’s not crazy for a guild to want to deal with their own incidents themselves, so the fact they turned up first, that don’t surprise me honestly. And the fact they took his body, who else was going to take it? What are they going to do, leave him lying out there to be looted by whoever finds him first? Someone’s got to deal with it.”

“It’s just with the strange things that have been happening,” Billiam said. “You know. Last week, with the guys coming here. I just feel like something bad is going on and I don’t really know what to do about it.”

Shrapnel did not follow that up, and Billiam did not make him.

“Look, don’t get me wrong. Someone’s shot in the middle of a speech in the middle of a public square, at Harvest Fest, something’s wrong with that, that’s for certain.” He scratched the side of his face. “But I don’t know. Maybe I’ve seen too many things go south when it comes to the guilds and their involvement. It don’t surprise me to hear there was a bit of trouble with the guilds following it.”

“Right. Okay. Well. I guess I’ll just get to work then.”

He spent the rest of the day out in the yard taking a transfer housing apart with a pry bar, and did not bring it up again.

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Calder woke in his dorm in the College spire with the whole day in front of him and nobody to tell him what to do with it, which is more or less what all his weeks look like. There are no lectures to attend at his level; there is a supervisor, and a problem, and however many hours you are willing to give it. So he gave it hours. He worked through the morning on the orthogonality question and wrote it up in the notebook he carries everywhere, which is also his spellbook. Then he copied the parts that mattered into a second book he leaves in his room. A man who carries his only copy of anything through the Bellows at night will lose it eventually.

Around midday he went to find Professor Buckman, because there were three things he wanted an opinion on and one of them had been bothering him since before the festival.

“Professor Buckman is, I’m afraid, off-site today, Calder.” The secretary did not look up from what she was writing. “As far as I understand, he is off-site indefinitely, until the project is complete. Over at the Guild of Engineers. Until that happens, he has informed me to inform you that you are free to continue your work as you see fit, and that he will return post-haste.”

“Right. That will slow the work down a little. I had a couple of questions.”

“Of course. If you wish to leave a message, I can have it sent to him.”

So Calder wrote a letter, and most of it was the research: the elemental axes and whether they are a real basis, and what it would mean if retuning turned out to be a rotation rather than a substitution. He numbered the questions and was careful to make it a proper letter about proper work, because that is the kind of letter Buckman answers. Then at the end, where a postscript goes, he wrote that something strange had happened at Harvest Fest. The Professor had known Theo as well. Theo had been killed with a weapon that was nothing like a normal pistol, which was very curious to a scientific mind, and did the Professor happen to know anything about that.

He sealed it and left it with her, and she said that a courier would take it across to the Guild of Engineers, and that he might expect a reply tomorrow, or in a couple of days, she was not sure.

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Lark came back to the depot at the end of the run and went up to Mira’s office.

Mira has run Brassline for years and has not gone out on a delivery herself in most of them. She looked up at what had come through her door: a girl with eye-bags down to her cheekbones who had been crying at some point and had washed her face since.

"You alright?" And then, because it was the obvious guess: "Was it those Below Boys again?"

"Mr Theodore. Theodore Blackwood. He's dead." Lark's voice did what it does. "They killed him. I was there."

"Dead?"

"Yeah."

"That's the, that guy that you like, right? The one you go and, you like his speeches and that." Mira sat back. "I wasn't into politics much myself."

"I was there. I witnessed it. And they just killed him."

"And who killed him?"

"I don't know yet. There were only a few people who stayed and everyone else just ran, and I stayed there, and then his guild came, and - " She stopped, and started again from somewhere she could get through. "Mira, I want to assist them finding out what happened to him. I know I'm asking a lot. But I think I need to take time off from Brassline duties."

Mira looked at her for a good while without saying anything, and then put both hands flat on the desk.

"Right. This was this business at Oblong Square, was it. I heard about it today, but I didn't know who it was or what happened. Details are scarce." She let that go by. "And what are you going to do? Investigate? You a detective now?"

"No. I don't know. But - " Lark's hands had come up in front of her chest without her noticing that they had. "Assassinated, I'm sure. So I just feel like it's wrong if it's going to be brushed under the rug like that. And I feel like I need to help, because I was one of the few people there who saw it. I don't know how I can help. I just need to be there."

"Well, look. I'm not going to tell you what to do, but I'll give you some advice. Don't get involved with those guild lot if you can avoid it. Sounds to me like you're already more involved than you should be." A pause. "But yeah. We can do without you for a couple of days."

And then Lark asked for the other thing, the part she had been carrying up the stairs with her, and she got it out badly. She said that she knew she was asking a lot again, but that she thought she could give a week's advance of payment on her accommodation, and that if she had not come back inside the week then Mira could rent the bunk out to somebody else. She did not mean that she would not want to come back. She just did not know what was going to happen.

Mira thought about it for a second, and what she said was not what Lark had braced herself for.

“Look. I tried my best to help you out, but at the end of the day I’m not your mother, and I’m not going to baby you about this. If you want to go, you can go. But you ain’t getting your bunk. I need that for another employee, I can’t hold it for you, and I can’t hold the position. If you go, you’re going.” She was not unkind about any of it, which made it worse. “Look, if we don’t find anyone by the end of the week and you want to come back, I’d be glad to take you on. But I’ve got a business to run here. I can’t be a hand down for nine or ten days because you think you’re a detective.”

There was a long moment in which Lark could have said yes, a couple of days then, and kept her bed.

“It’s the least I can do,” she said. “I feel like. Everything Theo has been talking about, and what happened on Kinsdae. It’s everything that’s wrong in this city. And if I don’t do anything, then there was no point in going to listen to him. All the work he’s done is just going to be brushed under the rug.” She was working the catch of it with her thumb while she talked, without looking down at what her hands were doing. “I’m sorry, Mira. And thank you for keeping me here this long. I don’t want you to risk getting involved in this either. So. Thank you.”

She put the Brassline pin down on the desk between them.

Mira looked at it for a while without touching it, and then picked it up and put it in a drawer.

“Look. If you don’t get yourself killed with whatever it is you’re following, then come back, alright? Otherwise I wish you the best. Just be careful.”

“Yep. Thank you.”

She had got as far as the door before she turned round.

“I’ll still bring out tomorrow’s delivery. Don’t worry about it.”

* * *

Billiam’s mother was home when he got in. She had been on call at the Institute the night of the festival and had missed all of it.

“You look rough.” She got hold of his face and pinched his cheek. “Did you get enough sleep there? You weren’t out partying all night with all your friends at the Harvest Fest, were you?”

“Of course I was. What else am I supposed to do at Harvest Fest?”

“Well, I’m glad to hear it. It’s good to have a strong social life, my boy.”

“So you haven’t heard what happened?”

“Oh, yes. Terrible business with Theo, wasn’t it.” She said it moving about the kitchen and did not stop moving. “Yes. Your father’s friend. Horrible to hear.” She had been carrying it around the Institute all day with nobody to put it down in front of, and here was her son. “All the other nurses were chatting about it, you know, at the Institute. We sort of expected him to be brought in. For healing. And it seems like everybody just waited around and nothing happened. He never turned up.” She stopped, with her back to him. “I don’t know. Was it really that serious?”

“From what I heard, he was, he was instantly dead.”

“Oh dear. Oh dear.” A pause. “And you were there, were you? Did you see it happen?”

“I saw it from a distance.”

She put her arms round him.

The two holes in his back had been shut since the night before. Two men he had known for half an hour had closed them, one after the other, and the skin had come back together over a stranger’s grey magic, and it still went off like a struck bell when she squeezed. Billiam held his face perfectly still and did not make a sound and did not tell her, and she held on a good while longer than that, patting the back of his head the way she has done since he was small enough to need it.

“There, there. It’s okay. Horrible things can happen in the city, you know. In a city like this you’ve got to really be strong, Billy. As long as you weren’t hurt.”

“Have you spoken to Dad?”

“Oh, your father.” She let go of him, and looked down, and found something on the table that needed moving. “I honestly haven’t seen him in a couple of days. He’s been sleeping at the office. Lots of really important work, he said. Some kind of project he’s working on. Very important stuff.”

“I wish he was home more.”

“Yes. Yeah.” She had her back to him again by then. “Look, it’s been a tough couple of months for us, Billy, I think you understand that. You’re doing great work at Claringbone’s, getting your feet under you. Don’t let everything at home here impact you too hard, alright? We’re doing all right, and we’ll keep working at it. Your father will come around. Once his big project’s finished we’ll have some more time and he’ll be back around.”

“Yeah. I hope so.”

They ate pork and beans, because that is what there is at the end of a month, and his father did not come home that night.

* * *

Calder spent that evening in the senior common room with a book he did not read, sitting near the fire where the talk was loudest and letting everybody forget he was there.

There was a great deal to listen to, because a guild man shot dead at a festival is the best conversation the senior common room has had in a year, and it went round the fire and came round again with additions. But what Calder took away from the whole evening was not anything that anybody said. It was the one thing that nobody said, which was that the weapon had been strange.

The story going round the College, and going round the whole city as far as he could tell, was that Theo Blackwood had been shot at close range by somebody standing in the crowd, over a debt or a grudge or a criminal connection that nobody could name and everybody was certain of. People had got as far as working out that it was an essence weapon, because of the sound it had made, and no further. Only four people in Parvo had knelt down and looked at that wound. Calder sat in the middle of the room and listened to every one of them be wrong about it. Nobody was calling it an assassination at all.

* * *

Aeska played that night to a room busier than any ordinary Aelsdae has a right to be, which he put down to a city that had had a fright and wanted company, and he cleared three marks, which is good money for the day after a festival.

He also listened, which is the actual skill. A bard who has done this for a living can play a room with his hands while his attention is entirely somewhere else, and people talk freely in front of a man making noise in the corner because they have decided that he is furniture.

What he heard was what Calder heard on the other side of the city: bad debts, criminal contacts, a grudge, somebody who got in close in the crowd with an essence weapon, and nothing about range, nothing about what a thing like that would cost to build, nothing at all that sounded like a plan. Under it, running through the room the whole evening, there was something else. Nobody knew what was happening to the body. Whether there was going to be a funeral, whether there was any family to hold one, who a person would even go and ask. Half the people in that tavern had shaken Theo's hand at one time or another and would have turned out for his funeral. Not one of them could tell him whether

there was going to be a funeral.

Afterwards he asked Harl whether any of the meeting regulars had been in that night, and Harl looked out over a full room and said honestly that he couldn't say. He doesn't take a roll call. A few faces it could have been. He'd seen them around.

* * *

In the morning there was a letter under Felix's door.

Mr Claudius, it is with our regret to inform you that you have been immediately terminated from the Guild of Engineers. Your services are no longer required following the unfortunate passing of Mr Theo Blackwood. As his aide and secretary, appointed by him himself, your service is no longer required. We thank you for your time. You are also evicted from this guild-owned tenement block and are expected to leave by the end of the day.

He read it twice, standing where he had picked it up, and the second time he read it slowly, the way he would have read a document that had come across his desk with something wrong in it, looking for the clause that would turn out to mean something other than what it said. There was no such clause. It was short, and it was signed by nobody, and it had taken the writer less trouble than a requisition. Yesterday morning he had been asked to sit in as interim Chief of Essence Transfer. He had said yes to that in a corridor with the drawers still hanging out of the walls.

"Ah," he said, to an empty room. "Well."

Then he put on his coat and walked to work, because he could not think what else to do with a morning, and because some part of him had not finished believing the letter.

He got as far as the doors he had walked through every morning of his working life, and one of the guards put out a hand.

"Sorry, sir. Mr Claudius, was it. You're no longer permitted access to the spire, as you're no longer employed here."

"Why am I being terminated? I got a promotion yesterday."

"I really couldn't say, sir, I just work the doors. Any complaints can be made to our human resources department. Expect a six to eight week reply on that, but of course, please feel free."

"Can't I talk to someone now?"

"I can put in a request for you. Who would you like to speak to?"

Felix gave the name of the Chief Secretary, and the guard walked a few paces off and turned his back and cast a small sending,¹ muttering into his collar. Then he came back with his face arranged the same way it had been arranged before.

"I'm sorry to inform you that Chief Secretary Spurnhold is no longer employed by the Guild of Engineers, and so your request has unfortunately fallen on deaf ears, so to speak. Thanks for your time."

Felix stood on the step for a while after that, with people going in past both his shoulders and none of them looking at him, and the letter still folded in his coat pocket, and until the end of the day to be out of a building he had never chosen to live in.

Then he went to Theo's house.

It is high up in the Stacks, and getting there is a matter of ladders and ramps and other people's washing, and he had only been a handful of times, to drop something off or to collect something, never for an evening. He remembered it as small and very neat, and from the outside it still was: the paint kept up better than anything on that street, the windows dark, the door shut.

He got out a knife to work the lock. The door swung open under his hand before the blade was in it. It had not been locked. It had barely been closed, and the wood of the frame was split away in a long pale wound beside the plate.

Inside had been taken apart. Not tossed about, but searched, and searched properly, every drawer out and every shelf swept and the contents left exactly where they had fallen. He stood in the middle of it in the dark, seeing well enough, and understood that whoever had done this had known the job and had not cared in the slightest who found out about it afterwards.

His trouble was that he did not know what he had come for. If he had been looking for one particular thing he might have been able to work out whether it was still here, and instead he went through it the way you go through a room when you are hoping to be told what matters, righting things and putting them down again. He looked for a diary, because most men keep one and because this was the only place Theo kept anything. He did not find a diary. In that mess he would probably not have found one if it had been there.

There was a knock at the doorframe, and a small old woman put her head in.

"Theo? Theo, is that you?"

"No. I'm Felix. I'm his secretary. I had to search something for him."

"Right. Right." She was looking at the room and not at him. "I didn't see him come home, you know. He normally comes and knocks on my door and says hi,

¹**Sending.** A short message spoken into the air and heard by one particular person wherever they happen to be, with room in it for a reply. Distance makes no difference to it, which is why a guild the size of a small town can be run without anybody walking anywhere.

and we have a little chat. He hasn't been back, so I've been a little worried. And now, oh, it's quite a mess in here. Was that you're doing?"

"No. Apparently someone was here before me."

"Hmm. Yes. I heard some noises in the house the other night. That's why I thought maybe he had, you know. Perhaps he'd been drinking or something. But he didn't come and see me."

"Did you see who went in here?"

"No. No, I heard some noises though. It was a couple of people at least. I thought maybe Theo had some friends or something arrive." She looked up at him properly for the first time. "Yes, I expected to see him this morning. Looking worse for wear. It was Harvest Fest after all, so it wasn't too unexpected. But yes."

Felix said that he had to leave now, and got past her, and got out.

There were people in the street. Not a crowd, but this is the Stacks and it is never empty, and four or five of them were standing about looking at Theo's open door and at the well-dressed man coming out of it in a hurry with his hands empty. They knew whose house it was. All of them did.

He did not look back to see how many of them were looking at his face.

* * *

Billiam went to the College of Arcanographers after his shift, to find his father.

He had not been back in a long time, and the woman at the desk did not know his face.

"Yes. Can I help you, young sir?"

"I'm here to see Benjamin Buckman."

"Let me check his availability for you." She ran a finger down a ledger without hurrying. "Professor Buckman is, I'm afraid, off-site today. Working on some sort of project. So I'm afraid he's not available to take visitors."

"Off-site? Do we know where?"

"I'm not at liberty to divulge his work preferences to someone who has just walked in off the street."

"Well, it's the thing." He heard himself starting and could not find the place to stop. "I'm his son, and he asked me to bring him something that he needed for work. He forgot his - " and there was a pause of exactly the wrong length " - lunchbox."

"Sir. It's five o'clock. We are far past lunch."

"That's why it's so important. You've delayed me."

She stopped running her finger down the ledger and looked up at him, and took her time about it.

“Billiam, wasn’t it. Yes. I have heard of your short tenure here at the College, and I understand that you were a disappointment then, and you are a disappointment now, as you appear to have not only failed to deliver your charge to your father but also failed to convince me that I should even entertain this request. So please be gone.”

“Well, at least I don’t forget my lunchboxes.”

He left.

* * *

Calder went home that day, which he does about once a week.

The Flynn house is half a workshop and always has been, with a bench where a table would be in another family’s house and tools laid out on it, and both his parents came in off shift covered in the day’s soot and looking pleased with themselves about something. His father saw him first.

“Oh. Look who it is.” His father put the bag down. “Been what, a whole day?”

“It’s been a week.”

“A week. Feels like we’ve never met. I almost didn’t recognise you.”

“Calder, I’ll put some food on,” his mother said, already moving. “We’ve eaten, but you’re a growing boy. Sit down.” And then, over her shoulder, while she was doing four things: “Have you been to see Orson? He always talks about you, you know.”

“Not yet. I’m going to. Is he having a good day?”

“He’s had a good couple of days, actually, yes. We go and see him every day, make sure he’s doing alright.” A small pause, and her hands kept going. “I can’t say he’s doing great. But he’s here and there.”

They talked about Theo, because everybody was talking about Theo.

“Horrible, horrible stuff,” his mother said. “People are saying he had some sort of criminal connections, and that he was attacked by some gang. People are saying the Below Boys were involved. Did you hear that?”

“I also heard that,” said his father. “I’ve heard horrible stuff about him being involved in all sorts of criminal dealings.”

Calder put his fork down.

“I’m not buying the criminal connections. I mean, you know how he was. He just tried to make the world a better place.”

“Yes, I was really surprised to hear it, honestly. I never took him for a criminal.” His father did not look up from his plate while he said it. “But that’s what people are saying. That’s what I’m hearing from everyone, all the lads down at the forge are talking about it.” Then he did look up. “What about you? You know anything about it? You knew Theo.”

“I don’t know anything yet. I mean, I was there when it happened.”

The kitchen went quiet.

“You were there?”

“Yeah.”

So he told them, and he told them most of it: the square and the speech and the shot and the running and the four of them round the body, and he left out the guards entirely, and the fire, and what he had done with it. His mother sat down halfway through and did not get up again, not even when the pot started going behind her.

“It feels so strange,” he said. “I want to figure out what actually happened. Because I don’t buy for a single second that it was criminal connections. It’s some sort of weird guild business.”

“Well, just don’t get too involved with that sort of stuff, you know.” His father had stopped eating as well by then. “It’s dangerous. To be shot in the middle of a street, in public? Whoever’s doing that has got some clear grudge or something. I don’t want you getting involved, Calder.”

“I promise to be safe. If it happens to be too dangerous, or too involved, then I back off. Yeah?”

His father looked at him for a moment across the table.

“Don’t you go lying to me. I know you well enough to know that you’ll get involved if things pique your interest. And I mean, that’s what makes you so bright. So clever. I’m very proud of you.” He said the rest of it more carefully, and more slowly. “But I don’t want you throwing away your scholarship and your position at the College for some trifles of criminality in the Stacks. You’ve worked really hard to be where you are, and I’d hate to see you lose it. So just be careful.”

“I’ll be careful. I’ll let you know if it goes badly.”

“Don’t let me know if it goes badly. Let’s make sure it goes well.”

His mother got up and started clearing plates that nobody had finished.

“You’d better go and see Orson before it gets too late.”

On his way out he did two things without saying anything about either of them. He folded the College robe away into the bottom of his pack, and out of a box in his old room he took a plain cloak, a workshop respirator and a pair of smoked goggles, and put those in on top of it.

Then he went next door.

* * *

Orson Thorne lives in a small side house on the Flynn plot, the sort of place a family builds for a grandparent, and it is full to the ceiling with books. There is a bed in one corner and a single table, and on the table one candle and whatever he is reading, and stacked around all of it the accumulated paper of about sixty years of a life spent asking why things work. He was at the table when Calder came in, and he looked up in the vague way of a man surfacing from a long way down, and then his whole face changed.

“Calder. It’s been so long.”

“It’s been a week.”

“A week? No. Surely it’s been months.” He waved it away, happily, and pushed a stack of something off the other chair. “You must tell me how it’s going at the College. You must be the Dean by now.”

“Not yet. I need to finish my thesis first.”

Then Calder got the notebook out, and the whole room changed with it.

This is the thing that nobody who has not sat in that room will believe. Ask Orson Thorne an ordinary question now and it slides off him: ask him what day it is, or when he last ate, and he will look at you very kindly and give you an answer that has nothing to do with anything. Put a problem in front of him and he is entirely and unmistakably there, all of him, at once.

They went at the orthogonality question for the better part of an hour and he followed every step of it. He argued about the basis. He wanted to know how Calder proposed to measure a phase that he could not observe, which is precisely the right question and the one Calder cannot answer, and he was delighted about it, and said so twice, and hit the table.

And then he sat back, and it went out of him.

“Now, Calder, you must tell me.” He leaned in, confiding. “You haven’t been teleporting anywhere, have you?”

“Of course not.”

“Good. Good, good, good. You know, we wouldn’t want anything bad to happen.” He tapped the table. “I must teach you one of those teleportation spells one of these days, you know. I’ll teach you.”

“Yes,” Calder said. “I’d like that.”

“See, I know all kinds.”

“You’ve taught me so many things.”

“Yes, yes. Well. You must learn. It’s very important, you know, very important in this day and age to understand everything that goes on. I myself, I know a few teleportation spells.” He nodded to himself, satisfied. “I’ll have to teach you one, one day.”

Calder said that would be good, and that next time he would bring more hours with him.

There was one more thing he had come for, and he put it as theory, because everything with Orson goes down better as theory. Suppose, he said, that you wanted to throw an essence blast a very long way, and suppose that you wanted to hit something with it.

“Ooh.” Orson sat up. “Interesting problem. To project an essence blast over such a long distance.”

“And accurately.”

“Accurately, yes. Quite a feat. Quite a feat.”

He started drawing. They went back and forth over it for a while, the old man sketching and crossing out and sketching again on the back of something he should probably have kept. What they arrived at together was that yes, it could be done. All the difficulty of it lay in keeping the thing fast and straight across the distance, and that is only a question of how much energy you are willing to put in at the near end.

“You’d need access to a lot of essence cores,” Orson said. “And a lot of money. That would be expensive to build, something like that. It wouldn’t just happen in the basement of some old house somewhere, you know.” He considered it fairly. “Well. You never know these days. People are getting brighter and brighter.”

“That’s good to know. It confirms what I was thinking.”

“Why are you asking me about this anyway?” It came out of nowhere, and it was sharp. “Odd thing to bring up.”

“I saw the aftermath of such a device. And I heard a loud bang. And I’ve heard rumours since, and I don’t want to work from rumours.”

“Good.” The approval was enormous and immediate. “The scientific method. Very important. Very important. Yes, yes. I’m glad you’re learning well.” He beamed at him. “How are things at the university? You Dean yet?”

Calder looked at the candle, which was low, and had been low for a while.

“Almost. It’s getting late. I think it’s time for you to sleep.”

“Right. Yes. Yes. Going to get the rest. Yes.”

He let himself be steered, and at the door he caught Calder’s sleeve.

“Well, look. Good to see you. Don’t let it be so long next time, you know?”

“Next week.”

“Next week. Yes.”

“And then you can teach me the new spells.”

“Yes.” His face lit up all over again, entirely new. “Yes. I’ll teach you some teleportation spells next time.”

* * *

Aeska spent most of that day trying to find out who Billiam was, and got nowhere at all. A first name and a description of a young Darkin is a description of several thousand people in the Stacks, and he was not willing to ask loudly enough to do any better than that.

Which left the one name he had been carrying around for two years without using it. Tobin Marsh had been the single person at the Guild of Engineers who stayed on his side when everything went wrong, and would be housed in a guild tenement somewhere in the Core, probably near the spire, because nobody walks an hour to work if the guild will put him closer. Aeska had not made contact in two years and had been extremely careful not to.

He asked Harl to put the word out. Quietly.

“I got you,” Harl said. “Don’t worry.”

* * *

Lark worked her last day that morning. She ran the route the way she has run it every Aelsdae and Ersdae for as long as she has been there, handed over what she was carrying, and came back to the depot for the last time. Then she packed everything she owns into a sheet and tied the corners of it. It did not take long. She stood for a minute at the end of a bunk that had been hers and was going to be somebody else’s by the weekend.

Then she put it all on her back and walked out into the Stacks, towards the Plumb and Bob.

* * *

They came into the Plumb and Bob one at a time that evening, and Harl enjoyed himself enormously.

Felix arrived first and took a corner table and ordered something strong, and Harl brought it over and leaned in with the discretion of a man who has never been discreet about anything in his life. "You're Aeska's friend, right? He said you lot might be here. If you want the back room, there's no one in it tonight." Then a wink, at close range, entirely unnecessary.

Calder came next, saw Aeska playing in the corner, went to the bar, got the same treatment, and gave Harl a long look on his way through.

Lark came in with everything she owned on her back and checked the room out of habit, which is how she noticed the older man in the flat cap sitting on his own at the bar and placed him from Theo's meetings, without ever having spoken a word to him in her life. She sat down at a far table instead. Harl came over with an enormous ale that she had not ordered and could not have paid for, put it down on a coaster, winked at her twice, and went away again. She sat with it for a while, faintly alarmed by the size of it, and when she finally picked it up the coaster underneath said BACK ROOM.

Billiam came in last, uncomfortable in the way a young man is uncomfortable in a bar he has not chosen, and asked Harl for apple juice.

"We've got some pressed apple. We normally use it for the cider."

"That sounds good."

Harl poured it and slid it across. "It's much better if you drink this in the back room. Tastes better."

"What do you mean, it tastes better there?"

"It's more private. In the back room. So people don't overhear you drinking it."

Billiam thought about this for a moment. "I guess that makes sense."

Aeska finished his set and came through last and locked the door behind him, and five people stood in a small dark room with drinks that most of them had not asked for, and nobody said anything at all.

"So," Calder tried. "How's everyone doing? Everyone still alive?"

"Before we get to that," Aeska sat down and gestured at the other chairs until they were used. "Let's start with the most important thing. I've now told you who I am and what my motives are. I think it's time that you start talking as well."

Nobody started talking. Lark gave it about five seconds, and then stood up, still holding the ale in both hands like a bucket.

"Okay. Um. Everyone, hello. I'm Lark. I'm a courier for the Brassline crew." A pause. "Or I was. I was a courier." Another pause, and this one was worse. "Um. Well. Does anyone drink ale? Because I don't think I can finish this."

Felix took it off her without a word.

"Thank you. Mr Volen - " she turned to Aeska " - or, I mean, Mr Aeska. Sorry."

"Let's keep it at Aeska."

"If you don't mind. I came here because I want to assist. I want to assist finding out what happened. And, well. Since there's only a handful of us, I think it's a necessity for me to be involved and help somehow." Her shoulders were climbing towards her ears while she talked, and she had got hold of one wrist with the other hand and was holding on to it. "Even though I don't know what I can actually do. I'm pretty fast. I can climb quite well. And I'm pretty handy. I can carry stuff into places, if you're looking for any person like that. Maybe I can help."

"From what I've seen," Aeska said, "you can handle yourself pretty well. Seeing the way you whacked that guard into oblivion." He let that land, and then went at it from the side. "But the biggest question I have is, what is your relationship with Theo? Because you were one of the first to run to him."

Lark looked round all four of their faces before she answered, one at a time, taking her time about each of them.

Then she told them. She had met him as a child, working down in the Bellows, and he had stopped and given her a word of encouragement and gone on his way, and she had kept it. When he started speaking in public she started going to listen to him. She stood by everything he had ever said. He had helped her out here and there, with self-defence among other things, and she said that part more quietly.

"We were not friends," she said, and did not seem certain what the word was supposed to cover.

Nobody said anything for a moment, and Aeska, who had been on the point of asking something else, did not ask it.

"I hope I can assist in any way I can," she finished, and bowed to ninety degrees.

"Okay, listen." He sounded, for once, genuinely thrown. "I'm not a lord any more. You don't need to bow to me. It's not necessary." He recovered somewhere in the middle of the sentence. "Whatever has happened has brought us together, whether you like it or not. But I'm more interested in you. Felix, was it. Seeing as you seem to have been pretty close to Theo in his last moments. What is your story?"

"Well. I worked with him for the last year. I was his secretary. That's why I knew him."

"And was your relationship more than work? Or just colleagues?"

"Mostly work." Felix had a good deal of ale in front of him now, most of it Lark's, and was making steady progress on it. "But we saw each other every day. Our offices are next to each other."

He said all of it to the table, and then went back to the ale, and did not add the thing about the word Theo had used twice in a street two nights ago. Aeska waited long enough to make it clear that he had noticed there was a wait, and then moved on.

“We might have to chat a little more later on. Seeing as you’re the one with the most information about the guild.” He turned. “And you. Kaldr, was it?”

“Calder Flynn.”

“What is your relationship with Theo?”

“He was a good friend of mine. My parents knew him as well.” Calder turned his glass round on the table. “But mostly, he’s just, he helped so much. I got a position at the College because he knew a professor there. Professor Benjamin Buckman. I got a research student position under him.” He shrugged. “And I’ve been hearing rumours that he was involved with some criminal organisation and that’s why he was killed. I don’t believe that. I want to know the truth.”

Billiam’s head came up.

“Wait. You work with Benjamin Buckman?”

“Yes. He’s a very smart man. Very nice person.” Calder blinked at him. “Do you know him?”

“How long have you been working with him?” Billiam said.

“Two, three years. Something like that.”

“I guess that makes sense.”

“I’m sorry,” Calder said. “I’m a little bit lost.”

“Has he ever told you,” Billiam said, “about his previous apprentice? Before you?”

“Not really.”

“I used to be at the College with him. Before you. And I knew that someone else started working with him.” He looked into the apple juice. “So I guess that’s you, then.”

Calder had taken that place three years ago because it was standing open and he wanted it. Not once since had he wondered why it was standing open. He said so, and it came out plainly, and it was the truth. Billiam turned his glass a quarter turn and left it there, and did not say the rest of what he could have said, which was that the man they were both talking about was his father.

Aeska watched the pair of them across the table and put it away for later.

“Well, Billy, was it? Let’s just say I haven’t seen you talk this much in the whole time we’ve known each other. And it seems the motivation for you to start talking was when Calder mentioned Professor Buckman.” He tilted his head. “So before I ask about your relationship with Theo, may I ask what your relationship is with this Professor Buckman?”

“Well, as I said. I used to be an apprentice with Professor Buckman. But that was a few years ago.” Billiam picked his way along it. “College wasn’t really a good place for me. I don’t like books as much, and I’m not really good with reading. So I tried to find a different job. And eventually it was Theodore who helped me get my job at the scrapyard.”

Calder asked whether he had worked on projects while he was there, and got a flat no: just studying magic and essence, and not a great deal of that.

“I’m just not that smart, maybe.”

The conversation went round to Aeska after that, because Calder had been waiting all evening to ask.

“You said you were kicked out of the guild. Can I ask why? It sounds kind of radical. You are part of the Volan family, after all.”

“Let’s just say that the guild was not for me. It was not the direction I wanted to go in. There were some disagreements, and I was kicked.” He waved the rest of it off. “It’s a long story. We’ll get to it when we need to get to it.”

“They’ll kick you out for no reason,” Felix said, to the table. “They will kick you out for no reason.”

Aeska looked at him for a second, and worked out that Felix no longer worked at the Guild of Engineers, and did not ask him about it.

“In any case. Some reason brought us together. I saw all of you standing around where everyone else ran away.” He spread his hands. “It doesn’t matter what your reasons are. I would like to get to the bottom of this. So if any of you have information you could share, that would be helpful.”

Calder gave them the rumours first, and then the part that mattered, which was that most of what he had heard was about the weapon, because it was so different from a normal pistol, and much more damaging, and would take very big skill to make and a great deal of money. He glanced at Billiam while he said it without meaning to.

Then Lark stood up again, which did not add much to her height.

“Sorry. I just want to address something. About what happened on Kinsdae, and going forward as well.” She got the whole thing out in one go, without stopping anywhere it would have been natural to stop. “I don’t usually like to be violent. But I feel like that situation was necessary, to defend ourselves from the enforcers. It surprised me how violent they were. It’s not something I regularly get into. I just wanted to point that out.”

She sat back down.

“I can understand that,” Aeska said. “I’m not a very violent type myself either. However.” He looked round at all of them. “Judging from the actions of those guards, and from what I know of them, from when I was still there, that is not

generally how they respond to a situation like this. And the intent of the guards who were there, as you could probably see, was not very friendly. So there has to be something else going on.”

Then he gave them what he had, which was that Theo had rented the back room of this bar every week for meetings that were not necessarily supposed to be on the books, and he turned to Felix and asked whether he had known about that. Felix had known that Theo did something political outside work. Not the details. They had never talked about it.

“Lark was one of the people who came,” Aeska said, and then stopped with his cup halfway up. “Wait. You have been at the meetings. In the back room. Not the speeches outside.”

“Yes.” She looked round at the rest of them. “I thought that was what I said.”

She had been telling them since the night of the killing that she went to hear Theo speak, and every one of them had pictured her standing in a square. She had meant this room, twenty feet from where they were sitting, on a Ersdae evening with the door shut.

“So,” Aeska said. “What were the meetings about?”

“I just attended to listen. I haven’t really been part of the conversation. People sit around and I sit at the back.” She thought about how to put it. “They were about, wouldn’t it be good if we didn’t have to listen to the guilds all the time about what to do. That we could have our own government. That kind of thing.”

“The start of a revolution.”

“No.” She was quite firm about it, and firmer than she had been about anything else that evening. “It was never like that. Nobody ever talked about doing anything violent. Nobody said we should overthrow the guilds. It was more, what if. Thinking out loud. It didn’t come across as radical.”

“And you’d recognise these people if you saw them?” Aeska said.

“Yeah. For sure.”

“Did you see anyone when you came in tonight?”

“Um. Yeah.” Her voice dropped without her deciding that it should. “There was this one guy. Older gentleman, with a, a flat cap. I recognise him. He’s been at the meetings. He was sitting at the bar when I came in.”

Before that could go anywhere, Billiam put his glass down and said the thing he had been working up to for an hour.

“One thing, before we do anything. I was really impressed by all of your fighting skills. I’ve never really fought like that. So if something like that happens again, I don’t expect anything from me. I’m not really a fighter. And I’d like to not fight at all, if that’s possible.”

“If we work together correctly,” Aeska said, “then maybe there’ll be no need

for fighting at all.”

“Yeah.” Calder had been quiet for a while. “And I think I also want to say that I really didn’t mean to kill that one guy. I don’t, I’ve never killed anyone. I’ve had to hurt some people in self-defence, slightly. But never lethal.”

He said it to the middle of the table, and afterwards nobody rushed in to fill the space.

“Well, self-defence or killing,” Felix said eventually. “Doesn’t really matter about that.”

“Listen here.” Aeska leaned forward. “What happened has happened. And honestly, I fear what would have happened to you if you’d been caught in that situation. Like you said, it was a matter of self-defence.” He turned to Billiam. “And as for you. I understand you do not want to get into any violence, and like I said, I’m not a violent person myself. But in order to prevent things like this happening, it would be better if we worked together, instead of trying to work against each other.”

“I agree with that. We should work together.” Billiam said it, and then said the other thing, and did not look away while he said it. “Please don’t cast any spells on me any more.”

“Yes.” To his credit, Aeska did not argue and did not explain. “I will make sure to keep those to only helpful spells. My apologies for that. Heat of the moment, and I wanted to do what I thought I needed to do.”

“I can see that now.”

Calder offered then to teach him some magic, if he wanted it: non-lethal things, ways out of a situation rather than ways into one.

“I’m not good with magic. I was supposed to learn it at the College.” Billiam turned his glass round. “But it wasn’t for me. I’d rather not mess with magic too much.”

“There are many non-lethal ways of using it.”

“It’s just too dangerous. For me.”

“You know,” Lark said, “sometimes it’s more dangerous to not do anything.”

“Maybe. Maybe you’re right.” He looked up at her, and then round at the rest of them. “But in the end, people die because of magic. And people get hurt because of magic. And I don’t want to be a part of that.”

* * *

Aeska went out to the bar to work on the man in the flat cap, and Harl knew him

at once.

“Oh, yeah. Barry, he’s called,” Harl said. “Comes in here every now and again. Works at one of the forges in the Core, I think. Seen him around. What about him?”

“Apparently he’s a regular at these meetings with Theo.”

“Wouldn’t surprise me. I see him around enough.” Harl shrugged and kept pouring. “Like I said, I try to keep my nose out of what happens in the back. That’s what people pay me for, discretion and that. But I’m afraid I can’t tell you much more about him.”

Aeska put a few pennies on the bar and asked Harl to keep the man where he was for a while: a drink or two on the house, offered the way a landlord offers one, with nothing in it that a man would think about afterwards.

Then he went back through to the others, shut the door, and told Lark what he wanted her to do.

“Right now this Barry might be our best lead. And you’re the only one here who knows him at all. Would you be able to go and talk to him?”

“The thing is, we haven’t talked to each other at all. We don’t know each other, and I don’t know if he’ll even recognise me.” She was already going pale round the mouth. “But I can talk to him. What would you want me to ask?”

“Introduce yourself. Say you have common ground, being at the meetings with Theo. But any further mention of them should be in a more discreet setting.”

“Okay. Do you want me to do that now?”

“I’ve asked Harl to keep him here. So now is a good time.”

“Okay.” Her hands had come up and folded together in front of her chest, and she looked down at them rather than at him. “I can do it.”

“Well, maybe this will help.” Aeska put a hand on her shoulder, and something crossed it that was neither quite music nor quite words, and a low radiant warmth came off his palm and went down through her arm and settled there.² “From what I’ve seen, you’re a lot more capable than you say. I know this seems like a huge task. But I know you can do more than you think. Good luck.”

“You’ve got this, Lark.” Felix tapped her on the shoulder as she went past, and left something behind on the sleeve that stayed there. She did not notice it. She noticed that she was walking a little straighter than she had been a moment ago.³

She took a breath and held onto it, and went out.

²**Bardic inspiration.** Not a spell, and no bard will let you call it one. A phrase of music, a word said into somebody’s ear, sometimes only a look, given away on purpose; and for a while afterwards the person who took it finds she has rather more in reserve than she had counted on.

³**Guidance.** A small blessing laid on somebody who is about to attempt one particular thing. It sits on the skin, faintly, until it is spent, and then it is gone.



Barry was up on a bar stool with a fresh drink in front of him, courtesy of the house.

“Excuse me, sir? Hello?”

He turned round on the stool and then had to look a long way further down than he had started, and did it cheerfully.

“Hello?”

“I guess you’ve maybe heard what happened on Kinsdae.” She heard her own voice wobble on the last of it and kept going anyway. “I’ve seen you in Theo’s meetings, sir.”

“Aw. Yeah. Awful business. Awful.” His whole face folded up. “He was my hero, he was.”

She got up onto the stool beside him, and he told her that he had not been there. He had been drinking in another pub down the way, and he gestured with his glass in a direction that could have been any of three, not on the square, so maybe luckily he hadn’t seen it. He had meant to come and listen. He had been drinking rather a lot that day and had forgotten, and he looked so thoroughly ashamed of himself about it that she nearly told him it did not matter.

“You went to his meetings a lot?”

“Yeah. Yeah, he had some right good ideas, he did. And he used to always chat to everyone. And he was a pretty big shot, you know, in the guild and that, so it was kind of nice. He was just standing there chatting with us. With all the rest of us.” He turned the glass round on the bar. “So yeah. I was at the meetings. And he always had good stuff to say.”

“And you’ve been hearing what they’re saying about him.”

“Oh, yeah. Yeah. People saying he was into criminals and that. But he was a good guy, he wasn’t into any criminal stuff, what I knew.” Then he stopped, and something else surfaced. “I mean. He had some. I saw him once. He was arguing with some people in here.”

Lark put her drink down and did not pick it up again.

“Arguing? Here?”

“Yeah, yeah. Couple of weeks ago, I think. Wasn’t before a meeting or nothing, it was just another day I was in here drinking like normal. And he came in, and he was normal, chatting to some people. And then these two people came in and they sort of, they confronted him. They went over to him.” He shifted on the stool. “I don’t like to eavesdrop. But it was loud. They was obviously arguing about something.”

“What did they look like?”

"They was dressed pretty smart. But not, I mean." He struggled with it for a while, wanting to get it right. "They didn't look like nice people, right? Not like me and you. Not like normal upstanding citizens. They looked like they was dangerous people. But they also looked like they was dressed kind of decent. And like they weren't really from around here."

"Can you remember anything? What colour were their clothes?"

"Oh. Colour. Oh." He thought about it properly, with his eyes shut. "Maybe green, I think. There was this one lady, she had a big green coat on. Like an overcoat type of thing. Big lady. Older lady, sort of grey hair, big green coat." He nodded, pleased with himself for getting it back. "And the guy. He was a bit scary looking. But a younger guy, like, I think he was probably Aela. Scars on his face he had. Looked a bit scary, yeah. I tried not to get eye contact with him, you know?"

"I wonder what kind of argument they could even have with Theo."

"Yeah. Like as far as I was concerned he's the nicest guy in the world. Who'd even be mad at him?" And then Barry leaned in and lowered his voice and became, for one sentence, a man who had thought about it. "Well. The thing is. Between you and me. He had some good ideas, did Theo. But I bet you, if some of the guilds heard them ideas, they wouldn't like it, you know? Be a lot of bad things for the guilds if people start, you know? Imagine if one of them big boys at the guild. They wouldn't like that, would they?"

"What do you think?"

"But he was in the guild as well, wasn't he." He sat back on the stool, and the thought went out of him as easily as it had arrived. "So they wouldn't kill their own guy, would they? That doesn't make sense."

"That wouldn't make sense, no."

She asked him what he thought would happen now, whether anybody would carry it on.

"I mean, movement's a bit strong, isn't it? We're just talking and that." He looked down into the drink. "And look. If it's not Theo, I don't think nobody's going to be running any meetings any time soon. Not after what happened. I'm not saying it's related to his opinions or whatever, right, I'm sure there's many reasons. But people are going to be scared for a bit. I don't think nobody's going to want to do any meetings on those kind of lines for a while."

And that was when the door opened.

A large woman came in first and a tall Aela man came in behind her, and both of them were wearing green overcoats, and the room went quiet in the way a room does when something walks into it that does not belong to it.

"Oi." She said it to the whole tavern, at volume. "Any of yous lot know Theo?" Nobody said anything.

Then, one at a time, the regulars turned to look at the bar: at Barry, who all of them knew, and at the small person sitting on the stool next to him, who several of them had seen going into the back room on meeting nights.

The woman followed their eyes and came over. "Look. You two knew Theo, did you."

"I didn't know him." Lark got it out steadily enough. "I just heard him speak sometimes."

The woman looked at her for a long moment and did not believe a word of it.

"Look, don't bullshit me, alright? You clearly know someone who knows Theo better." She put a hand flat on the bar. "We just got some unresolved business with Theo. And on account of his death, we're looking for someone who's able to finish that business for us, alright? So no need to look so scared."

Beside her, Barry had gone so far into his cup that only the cap was really visible.

"With all due respect, miss, I don't think I'm the person you should be looking for."

"Yeah. Maybe not." She looked Lark up and down and nodded slowly. "But maybe you know someone who's a bit more up the chain. Someone who knows a bit more about what's going on."

"Certainly not. I wouldn't know anyone like that, miss."

The tall Aela man took one step forward. He had not said a word since the door opened, and somehow there seemed to be more of him in the room than there had been.

"Yeah. Right. Look, we don't want to get - " The woman stopped herself. She glanced down the bar at Harl, who was standing very still behind it, and started again more carefully. "We don't want to cause any trouble in this nice establishment. So just tell us where we can find someone who knows a bit more about Theo, and you can get on with what you're doing."

Lark looked at Harl, and at a room full of people watching her over their drinks, and made the only decision that was available to her.

"Maybe, miss. Let's go outside. I can talk to you."

"Alright. We can talk outside."

* * *

In the back room four people were listening to a muffled female voice through a shut door, and Billiam got it open a crack to see.

He had the shape of it at once: Lark at the bar, Barry hiding in his drink, two strangers in green standing over the pair of them. He walked out and up to her before anybody behind him could get a hand to his sleeve.

“Is everything okay?”

“Yeah, it’s okay.” Lark shoved him back a step. “Just - ”

“Who’s your friend?”

“He’s my little brother. Don’t worry about him.”

The woman accepted this without much interest and went out through the front, and Lark followed her. The Aela man did not: he stayed just inside the door where he could see the whole room, and watched the patrons to find out whether any of them were going to do anything about it.

The other three went out the back. The back room has a door onto the alley and Aeska had the key to it, and he let them through without saying anything, and then Felix put a hand on each of them and took the volume out of the world.⁴ They went up the alley and round.

Billiam, left alone in a tavern, went and sat at the bar.

“Harl. What’s going on? I thought I heard some loud voices. Is that normal?”

Harl leaned in over the bar. “Nah. Your friend there - ” he tipped his head at the door “ - these lot are looking for friends of Theo, and she convinced them to go outside with her. I don’t know what that means. But they didn’t seem particularly friendly.”

“You think they might do something to her?”

Harl looked over at the Aela man standing by his door, and took a while about answering.

“I mean, I don’t know what they want. But like I said. They didn’t seem to be happy to just take no for an answer.”

* * *

Outside, Oblong Square was almost ordinary. There were traders packing up and passers-by cutting across and a scattering of evening business at the far end, and nothing at all on the cobbles to mark the place where a man had been shot two nights ago. Lark saw that the stones had been swept, and made herself keep walking.

“I’m sorry, miss. I just didn’t want to cause trouble for the barkeeper. Hurt his

⁴**Pass Without Trace.** A blanket of muffling quiet laid over a small group. It does not make anybody invisible; it makes them very hard to notice, and almost impossible to follow.

business.” She kept both hands where they could be seen. “What kind of person are you looking for? I’m just someone who’s gone to Theo’s meetings, to listen to him.”

“I don’t give a fuck about these meetings.” The woman said it flatly, and without any particular malice, which was worse. “What meetings are you talking about? I’m looking for someone who knows Theo. Who does business with him. You know?”

“I don’t know anyone like that that well, miss,” Lark said. “I’m sorry.”

While she was saying it she was looking. The coat was enormous and hung open badly, and there was brasswork pinned to what was under it. Lark has carried packages for a Porter’s crew for years and knows every badge they wear, and this was not a crew badge. It was the Porter’s Guild’s own.

The coat had also swung far enough back to show an essence weapon in a holster on the woman’s hip.

“You bring me to someone who knows Theo, and what he works on, better than you do,” the woman said, “and then you won’t have any trouble.”

“I just know the faces of the people from the meeting,” Lark said. “I don’t know their names.”

That was the third time she had been asked and the third time she had said the same thing, and the woman in the green coat stopped believing there was a fourth way of asking it.

She came off the wall fast. A hand closed round Lark’s throat and her back went into the brick and her heels came off the ground, and for a second she hung there in a stranger’s fist, in the open, forty feet from people buying bread.

Then she brought her knee up into the woman’s stomach, hard, and it was Theo who had taught her how. The grip opened. She dropped onto her feet and was moving before she had properly landed.

“Hey! Hey, stop!”

“I don’t know any names!”

She shouted it once, over her shoulder, at full volume, at a woman who had not asked her a question. Then she ran.

Thirty feet away, in the mouth of the alley, three people who had gone to considerable magical trouble to become the quietest objects in Oblong Square listened to the person they had sent out on a delicate errand announce her position, her innocence and her general condition to everybody within two streets.

Aeska shut his eyes for a second.

Then he opened them and went, and Felix and Calder went after him, and behind all three of them the tavern’s back door banged open on Billiam.